catch-all term ‘workers’. As one historian noted: ‘mobility was at least as characteristic of pre-modern India as sedentarism’.[81] The modern world would popularize words like ‘coolie’ and ‘kangani’, ‘professional’ and ‘pardesi’, and much more. It can be separated into two phases: one from roughly the middle of the 18th century to the late 19th century in which the power of the horse and wind still mattered, and the other since then till now, in which the horsepower of the engine increased the speed of travel over land, water, and most dramatically, air.

The first phase was closely linked with the disintegration of the Mughal Empire after Aurangzeb’s death in 1707 and the gradual colonization of India by European powers, led by the English East India Company after its victory in the Battle of Plassey in Bengal in 1757. One direct impact of European colonialism on spatial mobility was the effort towards settling nomadic groups, which throughout history had been on the move, most famously the Banjaras. Their lives were those of travel in *qafila*s (caravans), progressing at roughly 10 miles a day, with thousands of bullocks, each carrying goods weighing over 100 kg.[82] They would be well-entertained during their long journeys by jugglers, conjurors, astrologers, musicians and people with trained monkeys and dancing bears accompanying them. But the colonial authorities wanted to settle mobile groups, which were often armed with weapons, into sedentary peasants as a matter of surveillance and also as a measure to increase the land revenue tax base. Their tightened control on mobile groups in the early 19th century led to a small disruption which then intensified with the introduction of the railways in 1853. A few Banjaras turned to criminal activity, leading the authorities to brand them as a ‘criminal tribe’, while others settled down as local cattle herders. Some Banjaras, also called *Vanjari*s, migrated to Bombay to work as porters again, but this time on the platform of the technology that had displaced them: the railways. In southern India, the Lambada community of Hyderabad, equivalents of the Banjaras in the region, under the Nizam state and indirect British rule underwent a similar process of occupational displacement and surveillance checks. They transformed into agricultural labourers and then bonded labourers, and their